



Nathan: From the U.S. Marine Corps to data analytics

Hey, I'm Nathan. I'm a principal data analyst in the Trust and Safety Organization at Google. I joined the Marine Corps Reserves when I was attending college, and the reserve unit I joined was a field artillery unit. So after a challenging Marine Corps boot camp, I went to field artillery fire direction control school. And for those of you that might not know, fire direction control is considered the brains of field artillery, and we use all sorts of computers to do our artillery calculations. But just in case the computers went down, we also were trained how to use slide rules as a backup. And then, a year later, I had the opportunity to be activated as a truck driver instead of my primary job as a field artillery man and was deployed to Iraq to drive trucks for an infantry company. After I got back from Iraq, I finished up my bachelor's degree and then worked as an applications engineer in Austin, Texas, and eventually saw the need to pivot more to focus more on business. And that's when I really fell in love with data analysis was when I was learning a lot more about business. It actually took me a couple of years, when I really sparked an interest in data analysis to land a role where I got to do it full time and really get my hands dirty with the data. Some of the things I did to lay the groundwork to be ready and be qualified for that was I took a Coursera course on R and I also did some data science hackathons where you spend an entire weekend at some university. And they release the dataset Friday night and by Sunday afternoon, you have to come up with

some recommendations. So those were two really good ways to really prepare myself, get good experience and really show a strong interest in data analysis. My first job, where I got to do data analysis full-time was at a large bank and I was just in heaven. I got to really do SQL for real, and also I got to use Tableau a ton. Got to go to a Tableau conference. It was really cool. Then I was fortunate enough to get an opportunity to move to Google into my current role. That's in trust and safety. And what's super exciting and fulfilling about that is that similar to the military, it has an overall mission of protecting people, so that's super exciting for me. The things that were **instilled** in me in the Marines that I use to this very day would be attention to detail. That's super important in the military overall, but especially in field artillery. Secondly, is the importance of communication. You have your own details locked in. You need to make sure that those are communicated really clearly to other people that you're working with and the third would be collaboration. In the military teamwork makes the dream work. You really rely on the team. That's definitely been the case in my post Marine Corps career and jobs.